

Artificial Intelligence in Pla...

10 Claude Prompts That Replace a \$900/hr Consultant

The engineers earning \$300K+ in 2026 aren't smarter. They just know how to ask better questions.



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A colleague typed one prompt. Fixed a bug I'd been debugging for two hours — in 20 minutes.

That was my wake-up call.

After 3 years of testing AI tools across engineering, marketing, and business strategy, I've watched the same pattern repeat: the people winning aren't the ones with the most tools. They're the ones with the best prompts. And the

best prompts don't ask Claude to *write* something. They ask Claude to *think* like someone who charges \$900 an hour.

Here are the 10 I keep coming back to.

The problem isn't Claude. It's how you're using it.

Most people type into Claude the same way they Google something. Short. Vague. No context. "Write me a business plan." "Summarise this document." "Fix this bug."

Then they get generic output, shrug, and say AI is overhyped.

It's not overhyped. It's under-prompted.

Here's the mental model that changed everything for me: **Claude doesn't know who it's talking to.** By default, it assumes you want a polite, cautious,

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thinking you need, the output completely changes. You're not using a content generator. You're configuring a specialist.

The 10 prompts below each assign Claude a specific expert role, give it real context, and demand structured output. Copy them. Fill in the brackets. You'll understand the difference immediately.

The 10 prompts

Prompt 1 — The strategy consultant

What it replaces: \$350–\$500/hr business strategy session.

You are a top-tier strategy consultant with 20 years of experience advising Series A to Fortune 500 companies. I'm going to describe my business situation. Your job is to give me a structured strategic analysis: identify the 3 most important decisions I need to make in the next 90 days, the key risks I'm ignoring, and one counterintuitive move most founders in my position never consider. Be direct. Skip the caveats. Here's my situation: [describe your business, stage, and the decision you're stuck on].

Top highlight

The key phrase is “skip the caveats.” Without it, Claude hedges. With it, you get the kind of blunt thinking you’d get from a good board member.

Prompt 2 — The contract lawyer

What it replaces: \$400–\$900/hr contract review.

You are a senior commercial lawyer specialising in SaaS and B2B contracts. Review the following agreement and flag: (1) the 3 clauses most likely to hurt me if things go wrong, (2) anything that limits my ability to exit or switch providers, (3) any liability caps I should negotiate up or down. Assume I'm the vendor/service provider. Output as a numbered list with plain English explanations – no legalese. Here's the contract: [paste contract text].

Caveat I always include in my workflow: Claude isn't a licensed lawyer, and I use this for initial review before involving a real one. But catching the three landmines before the call? That alone saves 30 minutes of billable time.

Prompt 3 — The market intelligence analyst

What it replaces: \$5,000–\$15,000 market research report.

You are a market intelligence analyst. I need to understand the competitive landscape for [my product/service] targeting [my customer segment] in [region/market]. Give me: (1) the top 5 competitors with their positioning and pricing, (2) the gaps in the market none of them are filling well, (3) the single most defensible angle for a new entrant. Use your knowledge up to your training cutoff, and flag where I should verify with live data. Be specific – I don't need "the market is growing," I need names, numbers, and patterns.

Prompt 4 — The senior code reviewer

What it replaces: \$200–\$400/hr senior engineer review.

You are a senior software engineer who is deeply skeptical of this code and hates technical debt. Do a full code review of the following. Tear it apart: what would you reject in a PR review? What's the security risk I'm missing? What's going to break under load? What would you refactor first and why? Don't soften it. Here's the code: [paste code].

This is the prompt Boris Cherny-style thinking unlocked for me. Asking Claude to be *adversarial* about your own code is completely different from asking it to “check for errors.” The hostile reviewer framing surfaces things the polite assistant never would.

Prompt 5 — The financial model auditor

What it replaces: \$300/hr CFO advisory call.

You are a CFO who has seen 200 startup financial models and can spot the assumptions that kill companies. Review my model's logic and tell me: (1) which assumptions are dangerously optimistic, (2) what scenario am I not stress-testing that I should be, (3) what's the single number I should be obsessing over that I'm probably ignoring. Here's the model summary: [paste key metrics, assumptions, and growth projections].

Prompt 6 — The pitch deck critic

What it replaces: \$500–\$2,000 pitch consultant session.

You are a partner at a top-tier VC firm who has seen 1,000 pitch decks this year and funded 8. Read my pitch and give me your honest internal reaction – not what you'd say to be polite, but what you'd say to your partners after the meeting. What's weak? What's missing? What's the objection you'd raise in the investment committee that I haven't addressed? Here's my pitch: [paste deck text or bullet points].

Prompt 7 — The negotiation coach

What it replaces: \$400/hr executive coach for high-stakes deal prep.

You are a negotiation coach who has prepared executives for M&A deals, enterprise sales, and salary negotiations. I have an important negotiation coming up. I'll describe the situation, my goal, and the other party's likely position. Give me: (1) the 3 leverage points I have that I'm probably underusing, (2) the concession I can offer that costs me least but feels biggest to them, (3) the exact first sentence I should say to open. Here's

the situation: [describe deal, parties, stakes].

Prompt 8 — The hiring interviewer

What it replaces: \$1,500–\$3,000 executive search firm screening fee.

You are a senior talent partner who has hired for engineering and product roles at high-growth companies. Based on this job description and this candidate's CV, give me: (1) the 5 interview questions most likely to reveal whether this person can actually do the job, (2) the 2 red flags in their background I should probe, (3) what a great answer vs. a mediocre answer to question 1 would look like. Job description: [paste JD]. CV: [paste CV].

Prompt 9 — The crisis communications advisor

What it replaces: \$500+/hr PR crisis consultant.

You are a crisis communications expert. A situation has just emerged and I need to respond quickly. Tell me: (1) the worst thing I could say right now and why, (2) the core message I need to anchor to regardless of how questions are framed, (3) a draft first response – under 100 words – that buys me time without looking evasive. Here's what happened: [describe the situation and who the audience is].

Prompt 10 — The product strategist

What it replaces: \$400/hr product strategy workshop.

You are a product strategist who thinks in terms of jobs-to-be-done and has shipped products used by millions. I'm going to describe a feature I want to build. Your job is to challenge me: (1) what problem am I actually solving, and is it the right one? (2) What's the version of this that's 10x simpler but solves 80% of the problem? (3) what would you build instead if you had the same resources? Don't be encouraging – be rigorous. Here's the feature: [Describe your idea].

What makes these work

Three things every prompt above has in common:

Role specificity. Not “act as an expert” — act as a *partner at a top-tier VC firm who has seen 1,000 pitch decks*. The more specific the role, the more specific the thinking.

Adversarial framing. “Tear it apart.” “Skip the caveats.” “Don’t soften it.” This one instruction single-handedly changes output quality more than any other prompt technique I’ve found in five years. It removes Claude’s default politeness filter.

Explicit output format. Every prompt asks for a numbered list, a specific set of deliverables, or a concrete word count. Vague requests get vague answers.

I drop prompts like these every week. Follow me and stop paying for advice AI can give for free.

The honest caveat

These prompts are not a replacement for domain expertise when the stakes are genuinely high. I still send contracts to a real lawyer before signing. I still use a real accountant for tax filings.

What Claude replaces is the *first layer of thinking* — the \$300/hr hour where someone smart reads your situation, asks the right questions, and gives you a framework for the decision. That layer? Claude does it in 30 seconds, for free.

The \$900/hr consultant you actually need is now the one who brings judgment *after* Claude has done the first-principles work. That’s a fundamentally different — and cheaper — engagement.

The bigger picture

The engineers earning \$300K–\$500K in 2026 are not doing something magical. They understand that Claude is not a content machine. It’s a configurable thinking partner. And the configuration is everything.

Most people will keep typing short, vague questions and getting mediocre

answers. The people who learn to frame Claude as a specific expert, remove the politeness filter, and demand structured output will keep pulling ahead.

The prompts above took me five years of trial and error to develop. You just got them in five minutes.

Which one are you going to try first? Drop it in the comments — and if you've built a better version of any of these, I want to see it.

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